

## Traditional Métis Capote

By Dave Peltier

Over the past few years, I have been making a conscious effort to learn more about my Métis culture and history. While I've always known that I was Métis, for a long time I didn't really understand the significance of my culture or really appreciate the history of my people. I have taken the opportunity in most of my classes to write about legal issues that affect the Métis people in contemporary society, but Michael Jackson's Treaty and Aboriginal Rights course was the first chance I had to really look at some of the legal history of the Métis.

When reading about the numbered treaties, I found a few articles on the role the Métis played in bringing those treaties about. For many of them, Métis interpreters were used as go-betweens for the government of Canada and many of the signatory First Nations. One article in particular, "'Men of their own blood': Métis Intermediaries and the Numbered Treaties" by Allyson Stevenson, provided a great background for the role of the Métis in the treaty process.

For my project, I decided to make a traditional Métis capote out of a Hudson's Bay Point blanket. This would have been what some of those Métis intermediaries would have worn, particularly in the early spring or late fall. It was a daunting task as the only thing I had ever sewn was a pair of shorts in my Grade 8 Home Economics class. In addition to that, creating a traditional Métis capote demanded cutting up a Hudson's Bay Point blanket. If I made a mistake or failed, it would have been an expensive failure. Luckily, it turned out better than I could have imagined.

The first thing I needed to do was to purchase the blanket I was going to use. A new four point blanket from the Bay cost \$275. Luckily, I was able to purchase one online through EBay. It took a few different attempts before I was finally the successful bidder. It was great because I was able to purchase one quite a bit cheaper than from the Bay, and it was also a nice, old used one instead of a brand new one. There are several books about the history of the Hudson's Bay Point blankets, and many collectors are able to look at any given label and can determine within a few years what year that particular blanket was made. The elder who taught me how to make my capote had one of those books and while I don't know the exact year it was made, we were able to determine by looking at the label that it was made in the 60's.

Long before this class began, I already knew that I wanted to make a capote and had already been in touch with an elder in Victoria who was willing to help me cut out the pattern and teach me how to put the capote together. I was so excited when I learned that I was able to create a capote for this class and made arrangements to visit the elder during our reading

break. It was during this visit and the remainder of the reading break that I was able to complete my capote.

When I met with the elder, the first thing we went over was the different styles of capotes. She showed me some of the capotes she had made for herself and her husband, as well as some that she had been commissioned to make. Each one had some variations such as different amounts of fringe, hood and no hood, as well as individualized patches or differently positioned pockets. I had put quite a bit of thought into the design I was looking for. I wanted to keep it quite traditional, though with not quite as much fringe and with a shortened hood. Many people sew in belt loops and make a belt out of a strip of the blanket, but I wanted to keep it traditional and keep it closed with a Métis sash.

Once I had decided on which style I wanted, I had a couple of important choices to make. I had to decide where I wanted the points and the coloured stripes to sit on the capote. In the end, I chose to keep the points at the top of the collar and the stripes at the bottom and into the sleeve. One of the things that the elder stressed when we were preparing to cut the blanket up was that it was always important to limit waste as much as possible. Pieces that weren't used for the capote itself could be used to make pouches and other things. In the end, I gave all the scrap pieces to my mother who was quite happy to get them as she sews a fair bit herself.

After we had cut out the pattern, it was time for me to learn how to put it together. This involved learning how to do what is called the blanket stitch. The stitch itself is really quite simple and it was easy for me to make noticeable progress. The most difficult part is trying to keep the stitch lengths equal so as to keep a nice, regular stitch pattern. Once I was actually on the sewing part, it went rather quickly. We spent several hours sitting in the living room, talking about Métis politics and watching Olympic hockey. She kept an eye on me and helped show me how to do the arms and add the hood when I had reached that point. It was an amazing afternoon and evening, and other than watching Canada lose to the Americans, it was a great way to spend the remainder of the day.

By the time I left the next day, I had already sewn the two arms to the body of the capote and really only had to do some of the stitching along the ends as well as double stitching around the hood and neck. I finished the rest of it at home during the break while watching the Olympics on TV. With summer coming quickly, I'm not sure when I'll really get a chance to wear my capote out. I'm sure I'll wear it at the next large Métis event or something like that. I'm also hoping to make another one in the future, this time with one of the red blankets with a solid black stripe at each end. In any case, it is one project that I never thought I would be able to do in law school and am really thankful for the opportunity to use this as a way of focusing on the Métis culture and history.